

learn that discretion is the better part of valour is not misplaced ("Hors D'oeuvres", May 19). Both George Bush and Condoleezza Rice are ignorant of the decreasing per capita food consumption levels in India and the increasing food wastage in the US. Their observation that the cause of food crisis is the prosperity of the Indian middle class lacks credence. It is better to discard such ramble reflections of political leaders, instead of highlighting them. K.S. THAMPI, Chennai

To Reserve or Not

The unconditional reservation for women in Parliament is more likely to increase the power gap between the haves and have-nots and may also result in further reduce the representation of the under-represented sections of society ("Journey of Gender Equity", May 19). M.N. ANSARI, Delhi

The women's reservation bill is ill-conceived since it harms the very concept of a family. Only in certain cases will women have the time and energy to get involved in politics. Reservation is no requirement for women to emerge as leaders. With reservation, a woman will be persuaded to enter into politics by her husband so that he could virtually rule with the elected representative as a silent partner. S.R. DEVAPRAKASH, Tumkur

Babu's Pay Day

While certain posts and payscales have been downgraded, the Sixth Pay Commission has doled out

goodies selectively ("It Pays to be a Babu", May 12). Thanks to it, Rs 100 is now equivalent to over Rs 12,000 for certain privileged classes in babudom. When Justice Srikrishna could not do justice, can one expect a committee of IAS officers to correct such anomalies? A.K. SAXENA, on e-mail

Shedding Light

If electric power losses are controlled to 15 per cent, India can become self-suffi-

cient in power ("Power to the People", May 12). The steps taken by Rajasthan Government to implement power reforms are really bold and commendable. A case study of the same should be presented by the government to all the other states, in order to motivate them to shun narrow short-term political gains and initiate similar steps for the sake of the prosperity of the country. B.H. AGARWAL, Bhopal

LESSONS TO LEARN



'Heartland Revolt' (May 19) will take place in other states too, if the Congress expects every partyman to behave as minions of Rahul or Sonia. People like Akhilesh Das will rebel against them. Rahul has failed to revive the Congress in Uttar Pradesh and his road shows during the state's polls failed to improve its position. It seems no Gandhi can improve it.

A. SRIKANTIAH, Bangalore

Just because a lightweight like Akhilesh Das has quit, doesn't mean the fortunes of the Congress in Uttar Pradesh will change. This is nothing but a storm in a teacup. The Congress has to do much more than just road shows to break the monopoly of parties like BSP and SP. People's real problems have to be addressed.

Moreover, local leaders in the state should take an active part to revive the party which has been reduced to a minority status in the state's politics.

D.B.N. MURTHY, Bangalore

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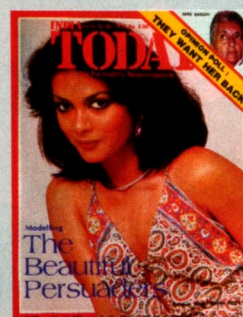
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Men and Machines

Exactly 25 years after the indomitable team of Sir Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay shattered the myth of Mt. Everest, another mountaineering myth—traditional bond of unity among the international mountaineering fraternity—has been rudely shattered. It is tragic that the controversy raised its ugly head during the colourful, week-long celebrations held in Kathmandu to commemorate man's conquest of Everest. The clash is essentially between the Norgay (left) "traditionalists", led by Hillary, who feel that "mountaineering should be treated as mountaineering and not as military manoeuvres", and a growing band of Alpinists, led by the Italians, who are tackling mountains with the aid of massive amounts of manpower, machines and modern equipment. In fact, now the Himalayas have become unusually overcrowded with huge expeditions taking place.



—Dilip Bobb